Nicki Young, M.A.

UX Researcher

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UX researcher with 7+ years of mixed-methods research across startups, nonprofits, and federal government. Pairs interviews, usability testing, and surveys with quantitative analysis, large-scale data scraping, and GIS to turn complex data into product decisions. Fluent in English and Spanish.

EXPERIENCE

Applied Research Lead (Historic Preservation Specialist) | FEMA — Jun 2023 – Present

Federal agency supporting communities before, during, and after disasters. Promoted to a senior role in Oct 2024.

- Lead a cultural research team by onboarding and training specialists in technical research practices, providing QC on and finalizing all cultural reports, and acting as the main point of contact for external stakeholders.
- Build team capacity by creating SOPs, review protocols, technical guidance, training, and staff workshops.
- Create research artifacts, metrics, and reports, and present findings to internal stakeholders, leadership, and external stakeholders in clear, defensible terms.

UX Researcher | OCN.ai — Dec 2023 – Aug 2024

Startup building an AI-powered ocean-health monitoring platform with government partners.

- Led geospatial research for the MVP: resolved **21** open How-Might-We questions and defined the 3 core mapping problems to solve before launch.
- Evaluated **4** spatial aggregation models and recommended a standard aligned with the satellite imagery the platform would use.
- Mapped task and user flows for every required MVP feature and led lo- and mid-fi wireframing, delivering the investor demo in **2 weeks against a 4-week plan**.
- Prototype demos helped secure **a new government partnership**; used feedback from live demos to improve navigation, the AI chatbot flow, and data charts.

UX Researcher | DAX Agency — May – Aug 2023

Startup design agency building data-driven dashboards.

- Scraped and analyzed **50,000+ restaurant reviews** (Octoparse, Voyant Tools) to find what drives ratings, defining the tiered metrics framework (Food, Service, Value) the dashboard was built on.
- Designed and distributed a survey that drew **156 responses at an 84% completion rate**, validating the metrics with diners.
- Turned findings into lo- and mid-fi wireframes; many proposed elements carried into the final MVP design.

UX Researcher & UX Writer | Tech Fleet — Feb – Apr 2023; May – Aug 2024

Nonprofit pairing cross-functional teams with mission-driven clients to build apps and websites.

- Food-sharing app: led **7 user interviews** (guides, moderation, co-coding, synthesis) and analyzed a **138-response survey**, shaping the consumer-to-consumer model and the MVP's safety and community features.
- Ran screener surveys, card sorting, and usability testing to build a user-centered information architecture.
- Nonprofit website: led part of a content audit and ran **2 rounds of message testing** that replaced vague mission language with specific, action-oriented copy; wrote a new issue page from scratch.

Senior Anthropology Research Lead | University of Central Florida — Aug 2017 – Jan 2021

- Led an end-to-end, multi-phase research study that resulted in several research artifacts still in use, presented findings to internal and external stakeholders, and trained undergraduate students in research methods and lab protocols.

SKILLS

Methods: User interviews, usability testing, surveys and screeners, card sorting, contextual inquiry, discovery research, competitive analysis, thematic analysis and affinity mapping, personas, task and user flows, content audits, data scraping and text analysis, geospatial analysis

Tools: Claude, Gemini, Dovetail (coding, AI-assisted synthesis), UserTesting, Google Analytics, Qualtrics, SurveyMonkey, Optimal Workshop, Figma, Miro, Notion, Octoparse, Esri ArcGIS

Languages: English, Spanish (fluent)

EDUCATION

M.A., Anthropology, and Graduate Certificate, GIS, University of Central Florida — 2020

B.A., Anthropology, University of Central Florida — 2017